

[2026 GenDD] Hackathon – Participant Handbook

AgTech Edition · HatchWorks AI & Syngenta · September 28 – October 2, 2026

Everything you need to compete. This handbook is the single source of truth.

1. What this is

For one week (Monday, Sep 28 – Friday, Oct 2), HatchWorks AI and Syngenta across every office and role compete – solo or in teams of up to 6 – to build working AI proofs-of-concept against real Syngenta business challenges. This is the third HatchWorks AI Hackathon, and the first run with an external client partner: Syngenta is providing the use cases, fielding its own competing teams, and judging alongside HatchWorks.

You do not need AI experience. You do not need to be an engineer. Past winning teams have included QA, product, design, and interns. You build part-time around your billable work, present live to a judging panel on Demo Day, and the best builds win cash prizes and may go on to become real proof points in front of Syngenta.

2. Key dates

When	What
Sep 3 – Sep 18 (closed)	Registration window
Sep 23	Teams finalized – matchmaking complete
Mon, Sep 28 · 5:00 PM ET (45 min)	Kickoff – all-hands welcome, fully remote. No in-person office events this year. Hacking opens right after.
Mon, Sep 28 – Fri, Oct 2	Hacking window
Fri, Oct 2 · 10:00 AM ET or 5:00 PM ET	Demo Day sessions
Mon, Oct 5 · timeslot still TBC	Awards ceremony – winners announced live, company-wide

Registration and team formation are already closed for this edition – if you're reading this, you're already on a team!

3. The challenge

Every team builds against one of the four use cases below; there is no own-proposal backup and no bonus for picking one over another.

Use case	What it's about
UC1 – Plant Capacity Utilization	Use plant conditioning/packaging and test data to improve capacity planning and scheduling decisions.
UC2 – Market Intelligence & Demand Capture	Turn market-sizing and demand data into actionable growth and planning signals.

Use case	What it's about
UC3 – Commercial Data Integrity	Detect, explain, and help correct data-quality issues in commercial/customer records.
UC4 – R&D Data Source Unification	Unify fragmented R&D data sources (trial, operations, lab/pedigree, germplasm) into one usable model.

Full detail on each use case – personas, data, scope, and success criteria – is in the official Syngenta Use Case Briefs, shared at kickoff. The one-line summaries above are a quick reference; treat the briefs document as the source of truth.

Use Case Selection: Teams do not need to commit to a specific use case upfront. You’re free to explore the four available use cases and decide which one you want to build against as the Hackathon progresses.

Use every AI tool you want. Generative AI tooling is mandatory across your process – requirements, stories, prototyping, code, and docs. The rest of your stack is free choice. HatchWorks provides temporary Cursor and Claude licenses for the hackathon month; see Section 7 for what happens to that access afterward.

4. Who can participate

- **Allocated delivery staff:** yes – but client commitments come first. This is volunteer time.
- **Team size:** up to 6 people, solo entries allowed.
- **Syngenta-facing teams:** Syngenta fields its own standalone teams this year – Syngenta teams are Syngenta-only, with no embedded HatchWorks engineers.

5. How you'll be judged

Judges Panel:

- HatchWorks AI:
 - Andrea Miller (VP, Delivery)
 - Doug Anderson (VP, Growth)
 - Luis Villalobos (Director of Labs)
 - Matt Paige (VP, Strategy & Marketing)
 - Omar Shanti (CTO)
- Syngenta:
 - Brandon Leander (Head IT & Digital)
 - Diganta Adhikari (Head of R&D IT Vegetables)

Every judge scores every team on the same core rubric. Two additional bonus categories are scored only by the matching organization's own judges.

Criterion	What judges look for
Business Value	Does it solve Syngenta's actual problem, on real or realistic data, with an actionable output?
Technical	Runs end to end live, right technique for the problem, checked against a baseline, repo handover-ready.

Criterion	What judges look for
GenDD / Agentic Dev	AI used across the lifecycle, not just for coding.
Demo	Live over slides, fits the time slot, a clear story from problem to solution, and the whole team visibly contributed.

Bonus (each scored only by the matching org's judges): Syngenta Pull (Syngenta judges only) – would Syngenta actually pilot this? HW Leverage (HatchWorks judges only) – something HatchWorks can reuse for future work.

Awards

Award	Prize	How it's decided
HatchWorks Choice Award	\$1,250	Highest-rated project across the HatchWorks judges' scorecards
Syngenta Choice Award	\$1,250	Highest-rated project across the Syngenta judges' scorecards
Brandon Powell Choice Award	\$1,250	The personal pick of Brandon Powell, HatchWorks AI's CEO – his criteria, no appeals

Total prize pool: \$3,750. A single team can technically win all three awards – there is no rule guaranteeing a winner per company.

Winners will be announced live the following Monday (Oct 5), so teammates across all time zones can join. **The exact time will be confirmed and communicated during the week.**

6. Presentation day – how it works

Demo Day is Friday, Oct 2. To let every team present at a reasonable local time, there are **two live windows** – there is no recording option and no third session for anyone who can't make either one:

- **10:00 AM ET** – a shorter window, capped at 4 teams, mainly for teams outside HatchWorks' usual time zones.
- **5:00 PM ET** – the main/default window, for every team not signed up for the morning slot.

Per-team presentation length – 12 minutes total: 7 minutes presentation + 5 minutes judges Q&A.

- Cover the essentials: problem & solution · technical approach · live demo · impact & scalability · how the team worked (GenDD counts).

Submission: a working prototype or demo, presented live, plus a one-pager and a repo link (Syngenta receives the code). You send your submission 1 hour max after your presentation.

7. Logistics & support

- **Single source of truth:** this handbook.
 - For HW: Slack: [#2026-hackathon](#) for questions – organizers answer daily.
 - For Syngenta: gabriel.antoniolli@hatchworks.com and mariana.bedoya@hatchworks.com.
- **Format:** fully remote.

- **Resources:** each team sets up its own environment, APIs, and cloud access (free-tier cloud + Vercel for demo deployments is the norm). Syngenta is providing data exports (synthetic or anonymized where real data isn't ready) for each use case.
- **SME Support:** each use case has one or two dedicated SMEs. If you have any questions, feel free to reach out to them via email or suggest a 15–20 minute call if you feel a quick conversation would help clarify things more effectively and avoid any misunderstandings. However, we ask teams to be thorough with their questions and only request time with the SMEs when truly needed, so we can be mindful of their time.
- **Use your tools efficiently.** Token and spend discipline is part of the hackathon's spirit this year, not just a cost note.

8. FAQ

Question	Answer
I'm fully allocated. Can I still play?	Yes, if billable work stays whole. Talk to your lead – many past participants did exactly this across the build week.
Do I need to know AI/ML?	No. Judges score product thinking, teamwork, and demo quality as much as technical depth. Use the AI tools to close the gap – that's the point.
Can we use tool X/Y/Z?	Yes – any tool, any stack, any model, as long as generative AI tooling is part of your process. Disclose what you used in your presentation.
Can we bring our own idea instead of a Syngenta use case?	No – this year, all teams build against one of the four official Syngenta use cases. There is no own-proposal backup.
What do we submit?	A working prototype or demo shown live in your presentation window, plus your presentation deck, a one-pager and a repo link. Your team must submit it right away after the demo.
When do we find out who won?	Not right at the end of Demo Day. Winners are announced live the following Monday, so every team – including members in different time zones – can be there for the reveal. The exact time will be confirmed and communicated during the week.

Prepared by the Hackathon 2026 organizing team. Questions: #2026-hackathon on HW's Slack or email one of the organizers.